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San Fernando Valley Ends Pride Month with March and Block Party

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In the summer heat, on June 29, the last Saturday of Pride Month, queer people and allies in the San Fernando Valley marched one mile down Van Nuys Boulevard with signs, banners and rainbow-colored attire.

Aztec dancers led the march, followed by Grand Marshal Hailie Sahar.

"When I think of pride, obviously I think of love and equality. I think of all different shades of colors, gender identities and sexual orientations, and I think of family. But I also think of those who came before us, who paved the way for us," said Sahar.

Members of the nonprofit Somos Familia Valle, who co-organized the event with State Sen. Caroline Menjivar and Mayor Karen Bass, led chants such as "No hate in the 818."

Elected officials in attendance included; Assemblymembers Luz Rivas, Jesse Gabriel and Pilar Schiavo; State Sen. President Pro Tem Mike Miguire and Menjivar; LA County Supervisor Lindsey Horvath; LA Councilmembers Bob Blumenfield, Hugo Soto-Martinez, Nithya Raman, Monica Rodriguez and Imelda Padilla; City of San Fernando Mayor Celeste Rodriguez; LA County Assessor Jeff Prang and more.

The march ended with a block party at the Van Nuys Civic Center, where attendees cooled down in the shade while enjoying music, drag and dance performances, resource booths, photo booths, crafting stations, a petting zoo, food and vendors.

"We're growing as a movement, ... we're growing as a community," said Kevin Al Perez, co-founder and president of Somos Familia Valle. "This is how we build community. This is how we build power."

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